



JTMUN XII

STUDY GUIDE

SPECPOL

Ambassadors,

It's our honour to welcome you to the most important General Assembly at this year's JT MUN, The Special, Political, and Decolonisation Committee. As your dais, we expect undeterred efforts from ambassadors representing their foreign policy to the best of their abilities. We expect delegates to remain intransigent, and present cogent arguments in relation to their stance and the topic at hand.

As your dais, we'd also expect delegates to enjoy the committee as well, as the dais has put thorough planning for this committee. See you on Thursday.

Regards,
The Dais.

INTRODUCTION TO SPECPOL

The Special Political and Decolonization Committee, commonly known as SPECPOL or the Fourth Committee, is one of the six main committees of the United Nations General Assembly. Its mandate encompasses decolonization, self-determination, peacekeeping, special political missions, and other questions bearing upon international peace and political stability. For delegates, SPECPOL is a forum in which protracted conflicts, competing claims to sovereignty, territorial disputes, and unresolved questions of political status must be examined through the framework of international law and multilateral diplomacy.

SPECPOL agendas rarely admit of facile solutions. Delegates must comprehend the historical trajectory of each dispute, scrutinize the interests and positions of its principal stakeholders, and distinguish established international precedent from contested political assertions. The committee therefore demands more than the reiteration of national policy. Delegates must determine the scope of legitimate UN action, assess the efficacy and limitations of existing mechanisms, and negotiate language capable of commanding support among states with divergent strategic interests.

The purpose of SPECPOL is ultimately to deliberate upon and formulate practicable international responses to complex political disputes. Delegates should interrogate three fundamental questions throughout the committee: what produced the dispute, what has the international community already undertaken, and what remains politically and legally feasible? Effective participation requires the ability to connect historical developments with contemporary realities, invoke pertinent UN resolutions and principles of international law, and formulate solutions that reconcile competing interests without compromising the feasibility of implementation. In SPECPOL, diplomacy lies not merely in articulating a position, but in constructing common ground where ostensibly irreconcilable interests converge.

AGENDA A

DECOLONIZATION AND SELF DETERMINATION OF WESTERN SAHARA

INTRODUCTION

Western Sahara is one of the United Nations' longest-running decolonization questions. It has been listed as a Non-Self-Governing Territory since 1963, when Spain transmitted information on the territory to the United Nations under Article 73(e) of the UN Charter. Spain formally ended its presence in the territory in 1976, but the territory's final political status was never settled.

The dispute principally involves Morocco and the Frente Polisario, with Algeria and Mauritania playing important regional roles. Morocco claims sovereignty over Western Sahara and proposes autonomy under Moroccan sovereignty. The Polisario Front seeks the exercise of Sahrawi self-determination and has historically advocated independence. Algeria supports the Sahrawi right to self-determination and hosts large numbers of Sahrawi refugees. These competing positions have prevented a final settlement.

For the United Nations, the issue is particularly difficult because it combines two principles that can come into tension in practice: self-determination and territorial sovereignty. The 1975 International Court of Justice Advisory Opinion concluded that historical legal ties existed between Western Sahara and Morocco and Mauritania, but that the evidence did not establish territorial sovereignty that would displace the application of self-determination.

The present UN process is also evolving. Security Council Resolution 2797 (2025) extended MINURSO until 31 October 2026 and called for negotiations that take Morocco's 2007 Autonomy Proposal as a basis while seeking a mutually acceptable solution that provides for the self-determination of the people of Western Sahara. The resolution was followed by UN-supported ministerial meetings in Washington and Madrid in January and February 2026.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

Spanish Colonial Rule

Spain established colonial control over the territory in the late nineteenth century and administered it as Spanish Sahara. The territory remained under Spanish colonial administration until the final phase of decolonization in the 1970s. By the 1960s, decolonization had become a central issue in the United Nations. Western Sahara was added to the UN list of Non-Self-Governing Territories in 1963.

Rise of the Polisario Front

The Frente Popular para la Liberación de Saguia el-Hamra y del Río de Oro (Polisario Front) emerged in 1973 as a movement seeking to end Spanish colonial rule. Following Spain's withdrawal, the conflict increasingly became a dispute involving Morocco, Mauritania and the Polisario.

The Green March and the Spanish Withdrawal

In 1975, Morocco organised the Green March, during which large numbers of Moroccan civilians entered the territory. Spain subsequently withdrew, while Morocco and Mauritania moved to establish control over different parts of Western Sahara.

The Polisario opposed this development and fought against both states.

Mauritania's Withdrawal

Mauritania renounced its territorial claim in 1979. Morocco subsequently consolidated its control over most of the territory.

The conflict between Morocco and the Polisario continued until the 1991 ceasefire.

LEGAL BASIS OF SELF DETERMINATION

The Western Sahara question is fundamentally tied to the international law of decolonization.

UN Charter

Article 1(2) of the UN Charter identifies the principle of self-determination of peoples as one of the purposes of the United Nations.

Resolution 1514 (XV)

The 1960 Declaration on the Granting of Independence to Colonial Countries and Peoples states that peoples of Non-Self-Governing Territories have a right to determine their political status and pursue their economic, social and cultural development.

Resolution 1514 is therefore one of the principal legal and political foundations of the UN's treatment of Western Sahara as a decolonization issue.

ICJ Advisory Opinion, 1975

The International Court of Justice was asked whether Western Sahara was terra nullius and what legal ties existed between the territory and Morocco and Mauritania.

The Court concluded that Western Sahara was not terra nullius and that historical legal ties existed, but it did not find territorial sovereignty ties sufficient to prevent the application of the principle of self-determination.

The Court's conclusion therefore became central to both sides' arguments, but it did not itself determine the territory's final political status.

FACTORS LEADING TO THE CONFLICT

Competing Claims

Morocco maintains that Western Sahara forms part of its territory. The Polisario Front rejects Moroccan sovereignty and seeks a political outcome based on Sahrawi self-determination.

Self-Determination versus Territorial Integrity

The core legal and political disagreement concerns whether self-determination should result in independence, autonomy, or another mutually negotiated status.

Failure of the Referendum Process

The 1991 UN settlement plan envisioned a referendum on self-determination. Disagreement over who would be entitled to vote prevented the referendum from taking place.

Regional Rivalry

The dispute has also become linked to relations between Morocco and Algeria. Algeria supports the Sahrawi right to self-determination and hosts refugee camps containing large Sahrawi populations. Morocco views Algeria as a principal supporter of the Polisario.

Resource and Economic Questions

Western Sahara possesses significant economic resources and has important fisheries, phosphate deposits and renewable-energy potential. This creates additional political and legal sensitivity surrounding economic activity in the territory.

CONSEQUENCES OF THE CONFLICT

Humanitarian Consequences

Decades of conflict have produced prolonged displacement and divided Sahrawi communities.

Large numbers of Sahrawi refugees live in camps around Tindouf, Algeria, where humanitarian assistance remains important.

Territorial Division

Morocco administers most of Western Sahara. The berm, a heavily fortified defensive structure, separates the areas under Moroccan administration from areas held by the Polisario.

Renewed Fighting

The 1991 ceasefire created a long period of relative stability, but the ceasefire broke down in 2020. Irregular clashes have continued since then.

Regional Consequences

The unresolved dispute has contributed to tensions between Morocco and Algeria and has complicated wider Maghreb cooperation.

It has also affected regional security, trade and political integration.

PAST UNITED NATIONS ACTIONS

1963 — Non-Self-Governing Territory

The UN formally placed Western Sahara on the list of Non-Self-Governing Territories.

1975 — ICJ Advisory Opinion

The General Assembly requested an advisory opinion from the ICJ concerning Western Sahara's legal status and historical ties. The Court maintained that self-determination remained applicable.

1990–1991 — Settlement Plan

The UN and Organisation of African Unity developed a settlement plan providing for a ceasefire and referendum.

1991 — MINURSO

The Security Council established the United Nations Mission for the Referendum in Western Sahara (MINURSO) to monitor the ceasefire and support implementation of the settlement plan.

The referendum was never held, making the mission's original objective one of the central unresolved questions in the dispute.

Baker Plans

UN Personal Envoy James Baker proposed political settlement frameworks in the early 2000s. Baker Plan I and Baker Plan II attempted to reconcile Moroccan autonomy with the possibility of a future referendum, but neither produced agreement.

Negotiations and the Political Process

Later UN efforts shifted increasingly toward negotiations for a “just, lasting and mutually acceptable political solution.”

UN Personal Envoys have attempted to bring Morocco, the Polisario Front, Algeria and Mauritania into negotiations.

Resolution 2797 — 2025

Security Council Resolution 2797 renewed MINURSO until 31 October 2026 and called upon the parties to engage in discussions taking Morocco's 2007 Autonomy Proposal as a basis for negotiations. It nevertheless retained the requirement that the final solution provide for the self-determination of the people of Western Sahara.

The resolution passed with 11 votes in favour, none against and three abstentions; Algeria did not vote.

2026 Negotiations

In January and February 2026, the United Nations and United States co-hosted ministerial meetings in Washington and Madrid involving Morocco, the Polisario Front, Algeria and Mauritania. The talks created renewed diplomatic activity, but significant disagreements remain.

THE CURRENT SITUATION

Western Sahara remains a UN Non-Self-Governing Territory.

Morocco administers most of the territory, while the Polisario controls territory east of the berm. The 1991 ceasefire has broken down, although the conflict has not returned to the scale of the earlier war.

The current diplomatic process is focused less on immediately organising the referendum originally envisaged in 1991 and more on achieving a negotiated political settlement. At the same time, the UN framework continues to refer to the self-determination of the Sahrawi people.

This creates the central contemporary question:

Can Morocco's proposed autonomy arrangement satisfy the principle of self-determination, or must self-determination include an independent Western Sahara as an available outcome?

STAKEHOLDERS & THEIR POSITIONS

Morocco

Morocco claims sovereignty over Western Sahara and considers its 2007 Autonomy Proposal the basis for a political settlement.

Under the proposal, Western Sahara would receive extensive legislative, executive and judicial powers over internal affairs, while Morocco would retain responsibility for sovereignty, defence, external relations and other national powers. The proposal also envisages a referendum on the negotiated autonomy statute.

Morocco argues that autonomy can provide meaningful self-government while preserving territorial integrity.

Polisario Front

The Polisario Front maintains that the Sahrawi people possess an inalienable right to self-determination and that this must be exercised through a free and democratic process.

In its 2025 submission to the UN, Polisario argued that the people of Western Sahara must themselves freely determine the territory's political status.

Algeria

Algeria describes Western Sahara primarily as an unfinished decolonization question and supports Sahrawi self-determination. It has rejected the idea that Morocco's autonomy proposal should predetermine the outcome of negotiations.

Algeria also argues that negotiations should be conducted directly between Morocco and the Polisario Front.

Mauritania

Mauritania renounced its territorial claim in 1979 and has since sought to avoid becoming a direct party to the dispute. It remains involved in the UN political process as a neighbouring state.

Spain

Spain is the former colonial power and therefore has a historical connection to the decolonization process. Its contemporary position is shaped by its relations with both Morocco and Algeria and by its broader interests in the western Mediterranean.

United States

The United States has recognised Moroccan sovereignty over Western Sahara since 2020 and supports Morocco's autonomy proposal as a potential basis for settlement while also supporting the UN political process.

France

France currently considers Morocco's autonomy proposal under Moroccan sovereignty the principal basis for a negotiated settlement and supports a UN-led political process.

European Union

The EU supports the UN-led process and, following Resolution 2797, has stated that negotiations should take Morocco's Autonomy Proposal as a basis while seeking a mutually acceptable solution that provides for self-determination.

African Union

The African Union has a particularly important role because the Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic (SADR) is an AU member, while Morocco is also an AU member. This gives the dispute an unusual institutional dimension within the continental organisation.

CASE STUDIES

Case Study 1 — Namibia

Namibia was a UN Non-Self-Governing Territory whose transition to independence was supported by a major UN operation, UNTAG.

The UN helped supervise the ceasefire, political transition and elections before Namibia became independent in 1990.

Relevance to Western Sahara:

Namibia demonstrates how the UN can play a direct role in transforming a colonial dispute into an internationally supervised self-determination process.

Case Study 2 — Timor Leste

After prolonged conflict and Indonesian withdrawal, the UN administered a transitional process culminating in a UN-supervised popular consultation in 1999. Timor-Leste subsequently became independent in 2002.

Relevance:

Timor-Leste demonstrates how international administration, voter registration, security guarantees and international monitoring can be combined to implement self-determination.

Case Study 3 — New Caledonia

New Caledonia remains a Non-Self-Governing Territory but has pursued negotiated autonomy and several self-determination consultations rather than immediate independence.

Relevance:

New Caledonia demonstrates that decolonization can involve prolonged negotiations over autonomy and political status rather than a single immediate independence process.

QUESTIONS A COMMITTEE MUST ANSWER

1. How can the United Nations facilitate the exercise of the Sahrawi people's right to self-determination?
2. What political options should be available in determining the final status of Western Sahara?
3. Can an autonomy arrangement under Moroccan sovereignty satisfy the principle of self-determination?
4. What role should MINURSO play in the future political process?
5. If a referendum is pursued, who should be eligible to vote and what safeguards would be required?
6. How can the political participation and human rights of Sahrawis be protected throughout the territory and refugee communities?
7. What role should Morocco, the Polisario Front, Algeria and Mauritania play in negotiations?
8. How should the United Nations address the humanitarian needs of Sahrawi refugees?
9. How can economic activity and natural-resource development benefit the people of Western Sahara while complying with international law?
10. What mechanisms can prevent renewed armed conflict and strengthen the ceasefire environment?
11. How can the UN reconcile the principle of self-determination with competing claims concerning territorial integrity?
12. What implementation and monitoring mechanism should accompany any final political settlement?

KEY TERMINOLOGIES

Self-Determination

The right of a people to determine its political status and pursue its economic, social and cultural development.

Non-Self-Governing Territory

A territory whose people have not yet attained a full measure of self-government and which remains under the UN decolonization framework.

MINURSO

United Nations Mission for the Referendum in Western Sahara.

Polisario Front

Sahrawi political and military movement that claims to represent the Sahrawi people and advocates self-determination.

SADR

Sahrawi Arab Democratic Republic, proclaimed by the Polisario Front in 1976 and a member of the African Union.

Autonomy

A system under which a territory exercises substantial internal self-government while remaining constitutionally part of a sovereign state.

Berm

The fortified defensive structure dividing the principal areas controlled by Morocco and the Polisario.

FURTHER RESEARCH

Delegates should consult the following before committee

United Nations — Western Sahara and Decolonization

[UN Western Sahara — Non-Self-Governing Territory](#)

International Court of Justice — Western Sahara Advisory Opinion

[ICJ Western Sahara Case](#)

UN Security Council Resolution 2797 (2025)

[Resolution 2797 — UN Digital Library](#)

UN 2026 Working Paper on Western Sahara

[2026 UN Working Paper — Western Sahara](#)

Morocco — 2007 Autonomy Proposal

[Moroccan Autonomy Initiative](#)

Algeria — Position on Western Sahara

[Algerian position on Resolution 2797](#)

European Union — Western Sahara position

[EU statement on Western Sahara](#)

United Kingdom — Security Council explanation of vote

[UK explanation of vote on Resolution 2797](#)

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[S/2025/664 — Polisario Front Position](#)

Embassy of Algeria. President Tebboune reiterates importance of just political solution to Sahrawi cause. 2026.

[Algeria — Position on Western Sahara](#)

Ministère de l'Europe et des Affaires étrangères, France. Interview with Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot concerning Morocco and Western Sahara. 2025.

[France Diplomatie — Western Sahara Position](#)

European External Action Service. Joint Communiqué following the visit of High Representative/Vice-President Kaja Kallas to Morocco. 2026.

[European Union — Western Sahara Position](#)

United States Department of State. The Ministerial Conference in Support of the Autonomy Initiative under Moroccan Sovereignty. 2021.

[US Department of State — Morocco Autonomy Initiative](#)

United Nations in Namibia. The UN's Role in Namibian Independence.

[United Nations — Namibia and UNTAG](#)

United Nations Peacekeeping. United Nations Transition Assistance Group (UNTAG).

[UN Peacekeeping — UNTAG](#)

United Nations Peacekeeping. United Nations Transitional Administration in East Timor (UNTAET).

[UN Peacekeeping — Timor-Leste](#)

United Nations and Decolonization. New Caledonia — Non-Self-Governing Territories.

[UN — New Caledonia](#)

UK Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office. Western Sahara — Safety and Security.

[UK Government — Western Sahara](#)

AGENDA B

THE ZANGAZAR CORRIDOR AND THE FUTURE OF REGIONAL SECURITY IN THE SOUTH CAUCASUS

INTRODUCTION

The South Caucasus has emerged as a critical point of competition between regional powers, with Armenia, Azerbaijan, Türkiye, Iran, Russia and the United States all holding significant strategic interests. At the centre of this competition lies Armenia's Syunik Province, whose geography connects mainland Azerbaijan to Nakhchivan while also preserving Armenia's direct border with Iran. The proposed reopening of transport links through Syunik has therefore developed into a dispute over sovereignty, security, economic connectivity and regional influence.

The issue has evolved significantly since the 2020 Armenia–Azerbaijan war. While Azerbaijan seeks reliable connectivity with Nakhchivan and greater integration into wider east–west trade routes, Armenia has insisted that any route through its territory remain under Armenian sovereignty, customs jurisdiction and security authority. The emergence of competing initiatives, particularly the Zangezur Corridor, Armenia's Crossroads of Peace and the newer TRIPP framework, has further internationalised the question.

For SPECPOL, the central challenge is to determine how regional connectivity can be expanded without undermining territorial sovereignty or creating new security tensions. The committee must consider the interests of the states directly involved while addressing the wider consequences for regional trade, transportation, security and the distribution of influence across the South Caucasus.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

The Nagorno-Karabakh conflict began in the Soviet era, when the region was placed inside Azerbaijan despite its Armenian majority, and escalated into war after Armenians in the territory sought union with Armenia in 1988. The First Karabakh War (1988–1994) left tens of thousands dead and displaced many more, ending with a ceasefire that left Nagorno-Karabakh de facto independent but heavily dependent on Armenia. Fighting flared repeatedly over the years, including a major war in 2020 that ended with Azerbaijan regaining much of the surrounding territory and Russia deploying peacekeepers to secure the Lachin corridor. Tensions deepened through blockades, border clashes, and Azerbaijan's 2023 offensive, after which it retook full control of the region and thousands of Armenians fled. Since then, Armenia and Azerbaijan have pursued peace talks, but disputes over borders, corridors, constitutional claims, international monitors, and legal accusations continue to block a lasting settlement.

GEOGRAPHY & STRATEGIC IMPORTANCE

Armenia's Syunik Province sits at the heart of South Caucasus transit politics because it links mainland Azerbaijan to Nakhchivan while also giving Armenia its only direct border with Iran. This makes it a strategic chokepoint in the competition between different regional transport visions: Azerbaijan and Turkey favor an unhindered east-west route through the south of Armenia, Armenia insists on preserving full sovereign control over its territory, and Iran opposes any arrangement that would weaken its land access to Armenia. Meanwhile, alternative routes such as the Middle Corridor through Georgia or a southern Armenia–Iran link remain important options, but Syunik continues to define the region's most sensitive geopolitical balance.

The Zangezur Corridor

The Zangezur Corridor was Azerbaijan's earlier proposal for a transport route through Armenia's Syunik region to connect mainland Azerbaijan with Nakhchivan, but Armenia rejected it because it was associated with an extraterritorial corridor that would weaken Armenian sovereignty; Azerbaijan's objective was to secure unimpeded connectivity—meaning open transit without Azerbaijani interference but still under Armenian jurisdiction—while Armenia insisted on preserving its own customs and border controls, full security authority, and territorial control. The paper argues that the newer TRIPP framework is more acceptable because it formally respects Armenia's sovereignty and allows it to keep transit fees, border checks, and legal control, while still creating potential economic benefits through new transport links, regional trade, and broader connectivity.

TRIPP — Trump Route for International Peace and Prosperity:

TRIPP is rooted in the August 8, 2025 Washington Declaration and the follow-up January 13, 2026 U.S.–Armenia implementation statement, which frame it as a peace-and-connectivity project rather than a classic corridor arrangement. The 2026 framework creates a U.S.–Armenia joint venture, the TRIPP Development Company (TDC), with 74% U.S. ownership and 26% Armenian ownership, and assigns an initial 49-year development term. The U.S. role is substantial through a DFC-owned U.S. vehicle, while Armenia retains full sovereignty, territorial integrity, customs jurisdiction, border control, and emergency authority over the implementation areas. The agreement also modernizes border and customs operations through a possible front office/back office model, but keeps core sovereign functions with Armenia. In relation to the older “Zangezur Corridor” idea, TRIPP is essentially the softer, sovereignty-protective version: it still links mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan, but explicitly does so on Armenian territory under Armenian law and authority.

COUNTRIES' POSITIONS

ARMENIA

Territorial Sovereignty

For Armenia, the central issue surrounding the proposed connection between Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan is the preservation of Armenian sovereignty over Syunik, the southern Armenian province through which the principal land connection would pass. The geographical importance of Syunik is considerable because it occupies the narrow strip of Armenian territory separating Azerbaijan from Nakhchivan and also contains Armenia's land frontier with Iran. The corridor question therefore concerns more than transportation. It is directly connected to Armenia's conception of its territorial integrity, control of its borders, and freedom to determine the legal and administrative conditions governing infrastructure located within its territory.

The terminology surrounding the route has consequently acquired political significance. Azerbaijan has frequently used the expression "Zangezur Corridor" to describe the proposed connection between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan. Armenia has generally preferred language centred upon the opening of regional communications under Armenian sovereignty. The 2025 Washington Declaration subsequently established the framework for "unimpeded connectivity" through Armenia while affirming the principles of sovereignty, territorial integrity and jurisdiction. The 2026 Armenia United States TRIPP Framework states explicitly that Armenia retains full sovereignty, territorial integrity and jurisdiction over TRIPP project areas.

For Yerevan, this distinction is fundamental. A transportation route can receive international investment, private operation and expedited procedures without becoming a sovereign corridor. Armenia's position therefore rests upon the principle that infrastructure located inside Armenian territory remains subject to Armenian law and Armenian state authority.

Armenian Control of Customs

Customs jurisdiction became one of the most contentious dimensions of the corridor debate. The 2020 trilateral statement stipulated that Armenia would guarantee the security of transport connections between Azerbaijan's western regions and Nakhchivan, with Russian FSB border guards designated to exercise control over the transport connection. The wording subsequently became a major source of disagreement over the precise legal character of the proposed route.

The contemporary TRIPP framework is substantially more explicit regarding Armenian authority. The 2026 framework states that Armenia retains sovereignty and jurisdiction over its borders and customs operations. Armenian authorities remain responsible for border control, customs and immigration control, taxation, government data systems, law enforcement and state

administrative functions. The framework permits modernised procedures and private customer-facing services in designated areas, while preserving Armenian state authority.

This creates an important distinction between unimpeded transit and extraterritorial transit. Unimpeded movement can involve streamlined customs procedures, digital documentation, coordinated inspections and reduced administrative delays. Extraterritoriality would imply a substantially different legal arrangement in which the territorial state possesses diminished jurisdiction. Armenia has consistently resisted the latter conception.

Crossroads of Peace Initiative

The Armenian government's Crossroads of Peace initiative provides its broader conceptual response to the connectivity question. The project envisages Armenia as a crossroads connecting Azerbaijan, Türkiye, Iran and Georgia through the reopening and modernisation of transport infrastructure. Its underlying principle is reciprocity. Connectivity should operate across the region through mutually accessible routes rather than through a single exceptional corridor benefiting one state.

The initiative therefore links infrastructure policy with diplomatic normalisation. Armenia seeks the reopening of railways, roads and other communications while maintaining sovereign authority over the routes. The European Union has publicly supported the Crossroads of Peace initiative as part of broader efforts to promote regional connectivity and reconciliation.

The strategic value of this approach for Armenia lies in converting geographical vulnerability into economic relevance. A country situated between several major regional markets can derive political and economic leverage from becoming an indispensable transit node.

Economic Incentives for Armenia

Armenia has substantial economic incentives to participate in regional connectivity. As a landlocked state with closed borders with Azerbaijan and Türkiye for much of the post-Soviet period, Armenia has historically faced significant constraints upon its access to surrounding markets. Reopening transport routes could reduce logistical isolation, attract foreign investment and create revenue from transit, infrastructure and associated services.

The TRIPP Implementation Framework identifies several anticipated Armenian benefits, including employment, foreign investment, technology transfer, training, new export opportunities and sustainable revenue streams. It also identifies Armenia's objective of developing itself into a regional transit and economic hub.

The economic calculation extends beyond transit fees. New railways and highways can stimulate logistics, warehousing, telecommunications, energy infrastructure, tourism and industrial

investment. The strategic question for Armenia is therefore how to capture these economic benefits without surrendering regulatory authority over the infrastructure that produces them.

Armenia United States Strategic Partnership

The corridor has become one of the principal mechanisms through which Armenia's relationship with the United States has expanded. The January 2026 TRIPP Implementation Framework established the project as a mechanism for strengthening American and Armenian economic cooperation. The May 2026 strategic cooperation framework subsequently broadened bilateral engagement into infrastructure, energy, critical minerals, technology, defence and security.

The TRIPP Development Company is envisioned as a joint venture in which the United States would hold a 74 percent controlling stake and Armenia a 26 percent stake during the initial 49-year period. The framework provides for Armenian authority over sovereignty, customs, border control and emergency response, with certain politically sensitive decisions requiring joint mechanisms.

This gives the corridor a geopolitical dimension extending beyond Armenia and Azerbaijan. American participation introduces an external security and economic actor directly into a region historically dominated by Russian influence and increasingly shaped by Turkish, Iranian and European interests.

Armenia's Changing Relationship with Russia

Armenia's relationship with Russia has undergone considerable deterioration since the 2020 war and the subsequent Azerbaijani military operations. Russia historically possessed substantial influence in Armenia through military cooperation, economic ties, energy dependence and Armenia's membership in Russian-led institutions. Russia also deployed peacekeepers in Nagorno-Karabakh following the 2020 war.

The transport provisions of the 2020 trilateral statement initially envisaged a Russian role in controlling the transport connection to Nakhchivan. A trilateral working group was established in January 2021 to address the reopening of economic and transport communications.

Armenia's subsequent foreign-policy trajectory has increasingly involved cooperation with the United States and European Union. The EU notes that Armenia's alignment with EU foreign and security policy increased substantially during the 2020s, while the European Union Mission in Armenia has operated along the Armenian side of the international border with Azerbaijan.

The corridor therefore intersects with a larger redistribution of external influence in the South Caucasus. Russian influence remains significant in several areas, including energy and economic relations, yet Armenia has sought a more diversified external security and diplomatic architecture.

Armenia Turkey Normalisation

The opening of regional transport routes is closely linked to the possibility of Armenian Turkish normalisation. Armenia and Türkiye have historically lacked diplomatic relations and their land border has remained closed for decades. Normalisation could provide Armenia with an additional western outlet for trade and reduce its economic dependence upon a limited number of routes.

The TRIPP framework itself identifies progress in Armenia Türkiye relations as one of the conditions necessary for the project's success.

A broader opening of the Armenian Turkish border would transform the strategic geography of the South Caucasus. Armenia could gain access to Turkish markets and Mediterranean transport networks. Türkiye would gain a direct route into the South Caucasus through a neighbouring state, while regional trade would become less dependent upon existing routes through Georgia and Iran.

AZERBAIJAN

Connection to Nakhchivan

The fundamental Azerbaijani objective is the establishment of a reliable land connection between mainland Azerbaijan and the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic. Nakhchivan is geographically separated from mainland Azerbaijan by Armenian territory, Iran and Türkiye. At present, Azerbaijan has historically relied upon air connections and routes through neighbouring states to maintain communication with the exclave.

The 2020 trilateral statement specifically committed Armenia to guaranteeing transport connections between Azerbaijan's western regions and Nakhchivan and provided for the construction of new transport communications.

For Baku, this connection has both practical and strategic significance. It would shorten transportation routes, improve national territorial connectivity and create a direct Azerbaijani land route towards Türkiye.

Territorial Connectivity

Azerbaijan approaches the corridor as part of a wider effort to establish uninterrupted transportation links across the South Caucasus. The route would connect Azerbaijan to Nakhchivan, then Türkiye, and ultimately the wider European transportation network.

Connectivity also strengthens Azerbaijan's role as a bridge between the Caspian region and external markets. Azerbaijan already occupies a central geographical position between Central

Asia, the Caucasus, Russia, Iran and Türkiye. The development of additional rail and road infrastructure can increase the country's value as a transit state.

Azerbaijani Post 2020 Strategic Objectives

The 2020 war fundamentally altered the regional strategic environment. Azerbaijan regained control over substantial territories previously administered by Armenian forces and subsequently restored control over Nagorno-Karabakh in 2023. Transport connectivity became increasingly important in the post-war regional order.

Azerbaijan has repeatedly presented the reopening of communications as part of the economic transformation of the South Caucasus. The objective extends beyond Nakhchivan to integration with Türkiye, the Caspian Sea and Central Asia.

The Azerbaijani leadership has also emphasised the construction of infrastructure approaching the Armenian border, including railway and highway projects intended to connect with Nakhchivan.

Azerbaijan Turkey Relations

Azerbaijan and Türkiye maintain exceptionally close political, military, economic and cultural relations. The expression "one nation, two states" has become a prominent description of the relationship, reflecting extensive cooperation across defence, energy, infrastructure and foreign policy.

The proposed route would reinforce this relationship geographically. Azerbaijan and Türkiye are already connected through Georgia and through the Nakhchivan Türkiye frontier. A functioning route through southern Armenia would create an additional and strategically direct connection between Azerbaijan proper and Nakhchivan.

Türkiye has also pursued infrastructure cooperation with Azerbaijan and Central Asian states through the Organisation of Turkic States and the Middle Corridor. The 2025 Ankara Declaration involving Türkiye, Azerbaijan and Uzbekistan emphasised transport digitalisation, railway and road infrastructure, logistics centres and facilitation of cargo through the Middle Corridor.

Turkic States Connectivity

The corridor has significance for the wider network of Turkic-speaking states. Türkiye, Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan and other members of the Organisation of Turkic States have increasingly promoted transport, customs and digital connectivity.

A route running from Türkiye through the South Caucasus towards the Caspian and Central Asia would reinforce the geographical continuity of this economic network. It could facilitate

movement of goods, capital and infrastructure investment across the Turkic states without requiring political integration.

Trans-Caspian Trade

Azerbaijan forms one of the principal western gateways of the Trans-Caspian International Transport Route, commonly called the Middle Corridor. The route links China and Central Asia to the Caspian Sea, Azerbaijan, Georgia, Türkiye and European markets.

The World Bank describes the Middle Corridor as a multimodal rail and maritime route connecting Chinese and European markets through Central Asia and the South Caucasus. Its development has become more significant amid disruptions and strategic concerns surrounding northern Eurasian transportation routes.

A functioning southern Armenian connection could therefore become an additional branch within a broader Eurasian transportation architecture rather than existing as an isolated railway or highway.

Azerbaijan's Position on Armenian Sovereignty and Transit

Azerbaijan has demanded reliable and unimpeded transit to Nakhchivan. The precise legal interpretation of "unimpeded" has historically generated disagreement. Azerbaijan's earlier proposals placed substantial emphasis on security guarantees and uninterrupted movement, while Armenia emphasised sovereign jurisdiction and customs authority.

The current TRIPP framework provides a negotiated institutional formula. Azerbaijan obtains the prospect of efficient and uninterrupted connectivity, while the formal framework governing the route affirms Armenian sovereignty and jurisdiction. The Washington Declaration established this approach through the language of reciprocal benefits and respect for territorial integrity.

TÜRKIYE

Türkiye Azerbaijan Relations

Türkiye views Azerbaijan as one of its most important strategic partners in the Caucasus. Defence cooperation, energy infrastructure, transportation and political coordination have created a dense bilateral relationship.

The South Caucasus provides Türkiye with a geographical bridge toward the Caspian Sea and Central Asia. Azerbaijan functions as the principal eastern partner through which Türkiye accesses this broader regional space.

"One Nation, Two States"

The expression “one nation, two states” reflects the exceptionally close cultural and political relationship between the two countries. It is frequently invoked by Turkish and Azerbaijani officials and is particularly relevant to transportation policy.

A direct connection through southern Armenia would strengthen the practical expression of this relationship by facilitating movement between Türkiye, Nakhchivan and mainland Azerbaijan.

Türkiye's Connection to the Caucasus

The Caucasus occupies an important position in Turkish foreign policy because of its geographical proximity, energy resources, transportation networks and relationship with Central Asia. Türkiye seeks to maintain influence in Azerbaijan and Georgia and has pursued diplomatic normalisation with Armenia.

A functioning regional transportation system would increase Türkiye's ability to operate as a logistical bridge between Europe and Asia. The country's existing ports, railways, highways and energy infrastructure give it considerable potential as a transit hub.

Access to Central Asia

Türkiye's interest extends beyond Azerbaijan. The Caspian Sea provides a maritime connection between Azerbaijan and Central Asian states such as Kazakhstan and Turkmenistan. From Azerbaijan, transport can continue through Georgia and Türkiye towards Europe.

This makes the Zangezur route relevant to a much larger Eurasian network. It can reduce the number of logistical discontinuities between Türkiye and Central Asia and strengthen the commercial relevance of the Middle Corridor.

Organisation of Turkic States

The Organisation of Turkic States has become an important platform for cooperation in transportation, customs, digitalisation, trade and infrastructure. Türkiye and Azerbaijan have promoted connectivity through the organisation alongside bilateral projects.

The development of interoperable customs systems, electronic permits, logistics centres and rail networks has the potential to turn cultural affinity into practical economic integration. The 2025 Türkiye Azerbaijan Uzbekistan Ankara Declaration illustrates the growing emphasis placed upon transport cooperation and Middle Corridor cargo.

Middle Corridor

The Middle Corridor provides the larger economic context in which the Zangezur route should be understood. It links China to Europe through Central Asia and the Caspian Sea before reaching the South Caucasus and Türkiye.

The World Bank has identified infrastructure bottlenecks, logistical inefficiencies and border procedures as important constraints upon the corridor's development. Improvements to rail infrastructure, port capacity, customs digitalisation and multimodal transportation can significantly increase its efficiency.

Türkiye Armenia Normalisation

Türkiye's normalisation process with Armenia is closely associated with the broader reopening of regional communications. Normalised relations could facilitate direct trade and transportation between the two countries.

For Türkiye, normalisation could produce economic benefits and improve regional connectivity. For Armenia, it could provide an additional western route. For the wider South Caucasus, the opening of borders could gradually replace a security architecture defined by closed borders with one defined increasingly by commercial interdependence.

Economic and Strategic Implications for Türkiye

Türkiye could gain from transit revenues, logistics, expanded Central Asian trade and greater relevance within Eurasian supply chains. The route could also complement Türkiye's broader ambition to function as an energy and transportation hub.

The strategic dimension concerns influence. Increased connectivity between Türkiye, Azerbaijan and Central Asia would enlarge Ankara's economic and diplomatic footprint across the region. Carnegie analysis has identified Turkish efforts to position the country as a major geoeconomic node linking Asia, Europe and surrounding regions.

IRAN

Iran Armenia Relations

Iran maintains a particularly important relationship with Armenia because Armenia provides Iran with one of its principal routes towards the Caucasus and Europe that does not pass through Azerbaijan or Türkiye. The Armenia Iran border is therefore strategically significant for Tehran.

Iran has consistently supported the preservation of existing international borders and has opposed arrangements that would substantially alter its access to Armenia or produce an extraterritorial corridor along its northern frontier.

Iran's Border with Armenia

The Iranian Armenian border is geographically narrow and strategically valuable. Syunik lies directly north of Iran, meaning any major change to the status or administration of transport infrastructure in southern Armenia has implications for Iranian access to the Caucasus.

For Tehran, maintaining a direct border with Armenia preserves an independent route towards Georgia and European markets. The strategic value of this connection has increased as regional transportation networks have become increasingly politicised.

Why Iran Opposes Any Loss of Armenian Territorial Sovereignty

Iran's principal concern has been the possibility that a corridor arrangement could diminish Armenian jurisdiction over a strip of territory bordering Iran. Iranian officials have repeatedly stressed the importance of existing international borders.

The concern is strategic rather than simply legal. A route controlled through an arrangement outside normal Armenian jurisdiction could alter Iran's position along its northern frontier, strengthen Türkiye and Azerbaijan's regional connectivity, and reduce Iran's importance as a transit route between Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan.

Carnegie analysis has identified Iranian concerns that the corridor could reduce Tehran's leverage over Azerbaijani transit and strengthen Turkish influence immediately north of Iran.

Iran's Existing Transit Routes

Iran has historically provided Azerbaijan with a route between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan. This gives Tehran economic relevance as a transit state and allows Azerbaijan to maintain communication with its exclave without crossing Armenia.

Iran has also promoted alternative international transportation projects connecting the Persian Gulf with the Black Sea and Europe. These routes can involve Iran, Armenia and Georgia, creating an alternative geography of Eurasian trade.

Iran's Access to the Caucasus

The Caucasus is important to Iran because of its proximity, trade routes, energy relationships and security environment. Tehran has sought to prevent the emergence of a regional arrangement that would isolate it from Armenia or place a hostile strategic alignment immediately along its northern border.

Iran also maintains relationships with both Armenia and Azerbaijan, although the relationship with Azerbaijan has periodically experienced tension over border security, regional alliances and Israeli Azerbaijani cooperation.

Azerbaijani Iranian Relations

Azerbaijan and Iran share a substantial land border, cultural connections and economic interests. Their relationship has nevertheless experienced strategic tensions.

Azerbaijan's close relations with Türkiye and Israel are particularly significant for Tehran. Iranian policymakers have also watched Azerbaijani transportation initiatives through the lens of their implications for Iran's northern frontier.

At the same time, Iran has demonstrated an interest in practical economic cooperation with Azerbaijan. The two states have developed transportation infrastructure and border projects that illustrate the coexistence of rivalry and economic interdependence.

Türkiye's Growing Regional Influence

A stronger Türkiye Azerbaijan transportation axis would increase Turkish influence across the South Caucasus and towards Central Asia. Iran already faces Turkish influence in the Caucasus, Iraq, Syria and Central Asia, giving the Zangezur question significance within a much broader regional competition.

A direct Türkiye Azerbaijan Nakhchivan connection through Armenia would reduce the strategic necessity of Iranian territory for certain forms of Azerbaijani transit.

Potential Impact on Iran's Regional Position

The corridor could affect Iran's role as a transit state, its influence over Azerbaijan, its relationship with Armenia and its strategic depth in the Caucasus.

Iran's preferred regional architecture therefore emphasises open transportation under the sovereignty of existing states. Tehran can benefit economically from expanded regional trade, while simultaneously seeking to prevent a transportation arrangement that could reduce its strategic relevance or alter the territorial balance along its northern frontier.

RUSSIA

Russia's Traditional Influence in the South Caucasus

Russia historically regarded the South Caucasus as an area of major strategic importance. Armenia maintained close military and economic ties with Moscow, Azerbaijan retained significant relations with Russia, and Moscow possessed important diplomatic leverage over regional conflicts.

Russia's influence was particularly visible through its role as mediator in the Armenia Azerbaijan conflict and through its military presence in the region.

Russian Peacekeepers after 2020

Following the 2020 war, Russia deployed peacekeepers to Nagorno-Karabakh under the trilateral ceasefire arrangement. The deployment gave Moscow a direct security role in the post-war regional order.

The 2020 statement also gave Russian FSB border forces a proposed role in controlling transport connections between Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan.

The subsequent collapse of the Russian peacekeeping presence after Azerbaijan's 2023 operation represented a major change in the regional balance.

Russian Role in Armenia Azerbaijan Negotiations

The November 2020 and January 2021 trilateral statements placed Russia at the centre of post-war negotiations. The January 2021 agreement established a trilateral working group composed of the Armenian, Azerbaijani and Russian deputy prime ministers to address the restoration of economic and transport communications.

This framework gave Russia an institutional role in determining how regional transport would be reopened.

Russia's Relationship with Armenia

Russia and Armenia have historically maintained close military and economic relations. Armenia has depended significantly upon Russian energy and has hosted Russian military forces.

The relationship has deteriorated substantially in recent years as Armenian authorities have criticised Russian security commitments and increased cooperation with Western institutions. Armenia's strategic diversification has included closer relations with the United States and European Union.

Russia's Relationship with Azerbaijan

Russia and Azerbaijan maintain pragmatic relations based upon energy, trade, security and regional diplomacy. Moscow has sought to preserve working relations with Baku even as Azerbaijan has developed strong relations with Türkiye.

For Russia, Azerbaijan is important because of the country's location on the Caspian Sea and its position within transportation routes linking Russia to Iran, Türkiye and Central Asia.

Russia Türkiye Competition and Cooperation

Russia and Türkiye simultaneously compete and cooperate across the Caucasus and broader Eurasia. Their interests overlap in energy, transportation and regional security. Their interests diverge regarding the distribution of strategic influence.

A southern transportation route could provide Russia with potential access towards Türkiye and Iran. A route increasingly integrated into American or Turkish strategic networks could produce a different regional balance.

Impact of the Ukraine War on Russian Influence

Russia's war in Ukraine has altered Moscow's strategic position across Eurasia. European states have sought alternative energy and transportation routes, while Central Asian and Caucasian states have increasingly explored diversified external partnerships.

The resulting geopolitical environment has opened greater space for Türkiye, the EU and the United States to engage directly in the South Caucasus.

US Involvement and the Reduction of Russian Influence

The American role in TRIPP represents a major transformation of the corridor question. The 2026 framework places a US government controlled entity at the centre of the proposed development structure, with Armenia retaining sovereign authority over the territory.

This does not eliminate Russian influence from the South Caucasus. It introduces a powerful external actor into a domain in which Russia previously possessed a much more dominant diplomatic and security role.

United States

Why United States became Involved

American involvement expanded significantly through the 2025 Washington Summit and the subsequent TRIPP framework. The United States has an interest in regional stability, diversified transportation networks, critical supply chains and expanded commercial access across Eurasia.

The August 2025 Washington Declaration established the political basis for developing TRIPP through Armenian territory.

US Strategic Interests in the South Caucasus

The South Caucasus occupies a strategic position between Europe, Russia, Iran, Türkiye and Central Asia. Its geography makes it important for transportation, energy, communications and emerging supply chains.

American engagement also reflects a broader interest in reducing excessive dependence upon routes vulnerable to geopolitical disruption.

US Armenia Relations

The United States and Armenia have expanded cooperation across infrastructure, economic development, border security, energy, technology and defence.

The 2026 strategic partnership framework identifies cooperation in critical minerals, rare earths, emerging technologies, energy security, border security and defence capabilities.

US Azerbaijan Relations

The United States maintains relations with Azerbaijan based upon energy, regional security, transportation and diplomacy. Azerbaijan's geographical position makes it relevant to American policy towards Central Asia and the Caspian.

US engagement in the peace process has also increased Washington's diplomatic relevance in Armenia Azerbaijan relations.

TRIPP

TRIPP represents the central American initiative in the contemporary corridor debate. Its purpose is to create multimodal connectivity across Armenia linking mainland Azerbaijan with Nakhchivan and integrating the route into the Trans-Caspian trade network.

The 2026 framework envisages rail, road, pipeline, fibre-optic and electricity projects under the broader TRIPP structure. The TRIPP Development Company is intended to operate as an Armenian incorporated joint venture involving an American entity and the Armenian government.

American Influence and Russian Influence

TRIPP changes the external power configuration surrounding the corridor. Russia previously possessed an institutional role under the 2020 and 2021 arrangements. The new architecture places the United States in a major development and investment position.

The significance of this development extends beyond transport. Infrastructure ownership, concession rights, communications networks, energy systems and border technology can generate long-term strategic influence.

US Interest in Alternative Trade Routes

The United States has an interest in transportation systems that provide alternatives to routes exposed to Russian geopolitical influence or other strategic disruptions. TRIPP can connect American investment and commercial interests to the Trans-Caspian region.

The January 2026 framework specifically identifies market access, critical supply chains and the movement of raw materials, critical minerals and rare earth metals as expected areas of benefit.

Energy and Critical Mineral Considerations

The South Caucasus is important for energy transportation and increasingly relevant to discussions surrounding critical minerals. Azerbaijan is already an important energy supplier to

European markets, while Armenia possesses potential strategic relevance in emerging mineral and technology supply chains.

The 2026 Armenia United States strategic partnership explicitly includes energy, critical minerals and rare earth mining among areas of cooperation.

EUROPEAN UNION

EU Involvement in Armenia Azerbaijan Relations

The European Union has played an increasingly significant diplomatic role in Armenia Azerbaijan relations. The EU has supported normalisation based upon mutual recognition of sovereignty, territorial integrity and internationally recognised borders.

The EU welcomed the August 2025 Washington agreements and the initialling of the Armenia Azerbaijan peace treaty.

EU Connectivity Initiatives

European interest in the South Caucasus is strongly connected to transportation and economic diversification. Armenia's Crossroads of Peace initiative has received explicit EU support.

EU investment in Armenia under the Global Gateway strategy has expanded, with the EU announcing expected investments reaching approximately €2.5 billion across sectors including connectivity and energy.

Energy Security

The South Caucasus forms part of Europe's wider strategy for diversifying energy supplies. Azerbaijan is already connected to European energy markets, making transportation routes through the Caucasus relevant to European energy security.

The development of rail, road, pipeline and electricity infrastructure can create a more integrated regional market and diversify routes into Europe.

European Access to Central Asian Markets

The EU increasingly views Central Asia as a region of strategic economic importance. The Middle Corridor can connect Central Asian producers to European consumers through the Caspian Sea and South Caucasus.

Improving the infrastructure of Azerbaijan, Georgia, Türkiye and potentially Armenia therefore contributes to European connectivity with Central Asia.

Middle Corridor

The Middle Corridor has become more prominent because it provides an alternative to northern routes crossing Russia. The World Bank has studied measures intended to increase freight volumes and reduce transportation times through infrastructure investment and logistical reform.

EU Monitoring Mission in Armenia

The European Union Mission in Armenia, or EUMA, was established in 2023 as a civilian monitoring mission. Its mandate involves observing and reporting along Armenia's border areas with Azerbaijan and contributing to confidence building.

Its mandate has been extended until February 2027. The mission has conducted thousands of patrols and forms part of the EU's broader contribution to regional stability.

European Interest in Reducing Dependence on Russian Routes

European policy since the Russian invasion of Ukraine has increasingly emphasised supply-chain resilience, energy diversification and alternative transportation routes. The South Caucasus is consequently more important to European connectivity policy than it was during earlier periods of relative Russian predominance.

REGIONAL SECURITY

Risk of Renewed Armenia Azerbaijan Conflict

The corridor question has historically existed within a broader environment of Armenian Azerbaijani military tension. Any dispute concerning the legal status, security arrangements or administration of a route through Syunik could generate pressure along the border.

The 2025 peace framework and subsequent diplomatic developments have created a new basis for normalisation, yet implementation remains dependent upon political agreements, border arrangements and domestic ratification processes. The EU continues to describe full implementation of the peace agreement as an important objective.

Border Militarisation

Syunik is strategically sensitive because it is simultaneously an Armenian border province, an Iranian frontier zone and the proposed location of major international infrastructure.

The concentration of transport infrastructure in a militarily sensitive region can create incentives for states to strengthen border security. It can also make the infrastructure itself a strategic asset whose disruption would carry economic and political consequences.

Security of Transport Infrastructure

Railways, highways, bridges, pipelines, fibre-optic cables and electricity infrastructure would become critical infrastructure if the corridor becomes operational.

Their protection would require coordinated border security, surveillance, emergency response, cyber protection and physical security. The TRIPP framework specifically assigns Armenian authorities primacy in emergency situations and preserves Armenian authority over infrastructure security arrangements.

Hybrid Warfare

The South Caucasus is vulnerable to forms of hybrid competition involving disinformation, cyber operations, political pressure, economic coercion and interference with infrastructure.

A transportation corridor creates additional targets for such activity. Disruption of a railway signal system, telecommunications network, customs database or electricity connection could generate effects disproportionate to the physical scale of the attack.

Cybersecurity

Modern transportation systems increasingly depend upon digital customs platforms, automated logistics, communications networks and interconnected databases.

The TRIPP framework contemplates digital tools and interoperable border systems. This creates efficiency gains and also increases the importance of cybersecurity, data protection and resilience against malicious interference.

Terrorism and Sabotage Risks

Large transportation corridors can become vulnerable to sabotage, organised crime and politically motivated attacks. Security arrangements therefore require cooperation among border forces, police, customs agencies and intelligence services.

The involvement of multiple states and private operators increases the importance of clearly defined jurisdictional responsibilities.

Protection of Railways, Roads, Pipelines and Telecommunications

The corridor should be understood as a multimodal infrastructure network rather than a single road. The TRIPP framework explicitly includes rail, road, oil and gas pipelines, fibre-optic infrastructure and electricity projects.

The strategic consequence is that disruption to one component could affect the functioning of several interconnected systems. Infrastructure resilience therefore becomes part of regional security policy.

Military Implications of Increased Connectivity

Connectivity can alter military geography. Faster movement of civilian goods also creates routes capable of supporting logistical mobility during crises.

The establishment of major infrastructure through Syunik could increase the strategic importance of the province and encourage stronger security guarantees from Armenia and external partners.

ECONOMIC & TRADE IMPLICATIONS

Trans-Caspian International Transport Route and Middle Corridor

The Middle Corridor connects China and Europe through Central Asia, the Caspian Sea and the South Caucasus. Azerbaijan is a central western Caspian transit state within this system.

The World Bank has identified significant potential for increasing freight volumes through investment in railways, ports, logistics and border procedures.

TRIPP could create an additional southern connection within this broader architecture, particularly if Armenia becomes integrated into regional transportation networks.

China Central Asia Caspian Caucasus Europe Trade

The geography of the Middle Corridor provides China and Central Asian states with a route towards Europe that avoids northern Russian territory. Cargo can travel through Kazakhstan and the Caspian Sea into Azerbaijan before continuing westward.

The South Caucasus consequently functions as a geographical bridge between Central Asian producers and European markets.

Türkiye Central Asia Trade

Türkiye's commercial relationship with Central Asia is increasingly dependent upon transportation connectivity. Azerbaijan provides the Caspian link, while Türkiye provides the western logistical connection towards Europe.

The Organisation of Turkic States has promoted harmonisation of transport procedures and infrastructure, strengthening the institutional basis for greater trade.

Azerbaijan's Energy Exports

Azerbaijan is already integrated into European energy markets through pipelines connecting the Caspian region with Türkiye and Europe. Additional transportation infrastructure reinforces Azerbaijan's importance as a regional energy and logistics hub.

Energy infrastructure also provides strategic leverage because pipelines require long-term political stability and secure transit arrangements.

Armenian Economic Development

Armenia could benefit from becoming a transit country rather than remaining geographically isolated from major regional transportation networks. Transit activity could generate employment, investment, customs revenue, logistics industries and new commercial partnerships.

The TRIPP framework specifically identifies foreign investment, employment, technology transfer and export opportunities as expected Armenian benefits.

Transit Fees

Transit infrastructure creates direct and indirect revenue streams. Direct revenue can arise through concessions, infrastructure charges and logistics services. Indirect revenue can arise from customs activity, fuel sales, warehousing, maintenance, hospitality and associated commercial activity.

The distribution of these revenues will be an important component of negotiations between governments and private operators.

Foreign Investment

The involvement of the United States in TRIPP introduces a large-scale foreign investment component into Armenian infrastructure. The framework envisages American financing and participation in development and operation.

European and Asian investors may also have incentives to participate if the route becomes part of a stable regional trade system.

Infrastructure Development

The project has the potential to stimulate construction of railways, highways, telecommunications systems, electricity infrastructure and pipelines.

Infrastructure development can also produce secondary economic effects by reducing transportation costs and connecting previously isolated communities to regional markets.

Supply Chain Diversification

The geopolitical importance of the corridor partly derives from diversification. States and businesses increasingly seek multiple transportation routes rather than dependence upon a single corridor.

The Middle Corridor, TRIPP and other regional routes can therefore be understood as components of a larger effort to build redundancy into Eurasian supply chains.

INTERNATIONAL LAW & SOVEREIGNTY

Territorial Sovereignty

Territorial sovereignty is the principal legal concept underlying the Armenian position. A state exercises supreme authority within its internationally recognised territory, subject to its international obligations.

The contemporary TRIPP framework expressly states that Armenia retains sovereignty, territorial integrity and jurisdiction over project areas located inside Armenian territory.

Territorial Integrity

The principle of territorial integrity is central to the contemporary Armenia Azerbaijan peace framework. The 2025 Washington Declaration refers to the inviolability of international borders and rejects the use of force to acquire territory.

The European Union has similarly framed normalisation around mutual recognition of sovereignty, territorial integrity and inviolability of borders.

Freedom of Transit

International law recognises the importance of transit and communication between states. Landlocked states have particular interests in obtaining access to international markets.

The legal challenge is establishing transit rights without converting them into sovereign rights over another state's territory. The TRIPP framework attempts to institutionalise efficient transit while maintaining Armenian jurisdiction.

International Borders

The route intersects with several internationally recognised borders: Armenia Azerbaijan, Armenia Iran, Türkiye Armenia and Azerbaijan Türkiye through Nakhchivan.

Any transportation arrangement therefore requires coordination between sovereign states, customs administrations and border agencies.

Customs Jurisdiction

Customs authority remains one of the clearest indicators of sovereignty. The TRIPP framework assigns customs and immigration control to Armenia, alongside law enforcement, taxation and government data systems.

The possibility of private operators providing front-office services represents administrative modernisation rather than a transfer of sovereign authority.

Extraterritoriality

Extraterritoriality is one of the most sensitive concepts in the corridor debate. An extraterritorial corridor would imply a legal arrangement in which the territorial state's jurisdiction is substantially limited.

The current TRIPP documentation does not establish Armenian territorial sovereignty as suspended. It explicitly states the opposite. The political significance of the arrangement therefore lies in reconciling high-speed or "unimpeded" transit with continued territorial jurisdiction.

UN Charter Principles

The UN Charter provides the wider normative framework concerning sovereign equality, territorial integrity and the prohibition on the use of force. The 2025 Washington Declaration explicitly situates the Armenia Azerbaijan settlement within the framework of the UN Charter and the 1991 Almaty Declaration.

2020 Trilateral Armenia Azerbaijan Russia Statement

The November 2020 statement is essential for understanding the entire dispute. Article 9 committed Armenia to guaranteeing transport links between Azerbaijan's western regions and Nakhchivan and provided for Russian FSB border control over the transport connection. It also envisaged construction of new communications connecting Nakhchivan with western Azerbaijan.

The January 2021 statement established a trilateral working group to implement the transportation provisions.

These documents form the historical legal and political foundation from which subsequent proposals developed.

2025 Washington Declaration

The August 2025 Washington Declaration represented a new diplomatic framework. Armenia and Azerbaijan committed themselves to efforts aimed at establishing unimpeded connectivity between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan through Armenian territory, with reciprocal benefits for Armenia. The declaration also established the political basis for TRIPP.

The significance of the declaration lies in the shift from an arrangement centred upon Russian mediation towards an American-backed framework centred upon Armenian sovereignty and international investment.

Armenia's Legal Authority Over the Route

Under the 2026 TRIPP Framework, Armenia remains responsible for border security, customs, immigration, taxation, law enforcement and state administrative functions. Armenian authorities also retain primacy during emergencies occurring within TRIPP implementation areas.

This creates the contemporary legal architecture of the project: international investment and private development exist within Armenian sovereign territory rather than replacing Armenian sovereignty.

COMPETING CONNECTIVITY PROJECTS

Zangezur Corridor and TRIPP

The traditional Zangezur Corridor concept refers to a connection through southern Armenia linking mainland Azerbaijan with Nakhchivan. Since 2025, the principal American-backed framework for this route has been TRIPP.

The terminology matters because “Zangezur Corridor” has often carried political implications concerning the degree of Azerbaijani access and Armenian jurisdiction. TRIPP is framed through sovereignty, territorial integrity, reciprocal benefits and American Armenian cooperation.

Armenia’s Crossroads of Peace

Crossroads of Peace is Armenia’s proposal for a comprehensive regional transportation architecture. Its underlying concept is reciprocal opening of roads and railways across Armenia, Azerbaijan, Türkiye, Georgia and Iran.

The project would make Armenia a participant in several transportation networks rather than establishing a single exceptional route dedicated primarily to Azerbaijani access to Nakhchivan. The EU has explicitly supported the initiative.

Middle Corridor

The Middle Corridor is a trans-Caspian transportation network connecting China and Europe through Central Asia, Azerbaijan, Georgia and Türkiye. It is primarily a trade and logistics project rather than a bilateral territorial arrangement.

Its importance derives from the diversification of Eurasian transportation routes and the increasing strategic value of the Caspian region.

North South Transport Corridor

The International North South Transport Corridor connects India, Iran, the Caspian region and Russia through multimodal transport routes. Its significance lies in connecting the Indian Ocean with northern Eurasia.

Iran views such transportation systems as an opportunity to strengthen its position as a major transit state. The development of routes through Armenia and Azerbaijan therefore takes place within a larger competition between multiple north south and east west corridors.

Iran's Alternative Routes

Iran possesses several potential routes linking the Persian Gulf to the Caucasus and Europe. One important concept involves transport from Iranian ports through Armenia and Georgia towards the Black Sea.

These routes provide Tehran with alternatives to a transportation architecture dominated by Türkiye and Azerbaijan. They also provide Armenia with an additional strategic argument for maintaining diverse external connectivity.

Türkiye's East West Connectivity

Türkiye seeks to establish itself as a major bridge between Europe, the Caucasus, Central Asia and the Middle East. The Middle Corridor, Azerbaijan Türkiye infrastructure and broader Turkic connectivity projects all contribute to this objective.

A functioning connection through Armenia could strengthen Türkiye's geographical position and reduce dependence upon routes passing through Georgia.

Russian Transport Routes

Russia has historically relied upon transportation links through the Caucasus and Caspian region to maintain connections with Türkiye, Iran and other Eurasian markets.

The 2020 and 2021 trilateral arrangements envisaged Russian involvement in the reopening of regional transportation links. The emergence of TRIPP introduces a different institutional model, with American participation becoming central to development and Armenia retaining sovereign control.

The South Caucasus can therefore be understood as a junction between several competing transportation geometries: the Middle Corridor, the North South Transport Corridor, Türkiye's east west network, Iranian routes, Russian routes and the emerging TRIPP framework.

The security significance of the Zangezur question ultimately derives from this intersection. The route connects a relatively small geographical area to an exceptionally large strategic system encompassing the Caspian Sea, Central Asia, Türkiye, Iran, Russia, Europe and the United States. Its future will consequently depend upon the interaction between sovereignty, commercial interests, border security, great-power competition and the durability of Armenia Azerbaijan normalisation.

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SPECIALIZED ROPs

SPECPOL will be following these Specialized Rules of Procedure.

[REDACTED]

Ambassadors,

The Dais adores its discretion.